PRACTICE EXAM 06 / EXAM SET 01

Domain 6: Communication and Customer Service

12 scored questions	4 answer choices per question	Answer key + explanations included

Instructions

Choose the single best answer (A, B, C, or D) for each question. Mark your responses before checking the answer key and detailed explanations at the end of this document. These practice questions are not official NHA examination items.

QUESTIONS

Q01 | Patient-Centered Communication

> **SCENARIO** During intake, a patient says, "I have several things to discuss, but at my last visit I only got through one." The medical assistant has not yet asked about the patient's concerns.

Which response best helps establish the patient's agenda?

A. "Let us finish the intake form, and then you can choose one concern."
B. "Which concern do you think will take the provider the least time?"
C. "What concerns would you like me to share with the provider today?"
D. "Would you like me to list the concern from your last visit again?"

Q02 | Accessible and Inclusive Communication

> **SCENARIO** A patient who prefers to discuss health information in Spanish arrives with a 13-year-old child who offers to interpret. A qualified Spanish interpreter is available through the clinic's video service, and the patient agrees to use that service.

Which action best supports an accurate intake conversation?

A. Connect the qualified interpreter and address the patient directly.
B. Ask the child to interpret and use the video service for unfamiliar words.
C. Use a translation application and have the child confirm the responses.
D. Ask questions in English more slowly and have the patient nod to confirm.

Q03 | Telephone Written and Virtual Communication

SCENARIO After identity verification, a caller reports lightheadedness beginning this morning after starting a new prescription yesterday. The caller says, "I have not fainted, but I want to know whether to take the next dose." The medical assistant has confirmed the medication name, the patient's callback number, and current location. Clinic policy requires immediate live transfer of symptom calls to the triage nurse, who is available.

Which handoff best relays the call to the nurse?

A. "The patient started a prescription yesterday and felt lightheaded this morning. I verified contact details and asked them to await your callback after appointments."

B. "The patient started a prescription yesterday and felt lightheaded this morning. I advised skipping the next dose and will connect them for confirmation."

C. "The patient has not fainted and wants prescription instructions. I verified contact details and will route a routine message about when to take the medicine."

D. "The patient reports lightheadedness this morning after starting a prescription yesterday and asks about the next dose. I have verified details for live transfer."

Q04 | Accessible and Inclusive Communication

SCENARIO At a noisy reception desk, a patient wearing hearing aids asks the medical assistant to repeat a simple check-in question. The patient says that facing the speaker and reducing background noise usually helps.

Which adjustment best matches the patient's stated needs?

A. Stay at the desk and repeat the question using a louder voice.

B. Move to a quieter area and face the patient while speaking clearly.

C. Write the question without first trying the patient's preferred approach.

D. Stand beside the patient and speak slowly toward one hearing aid.

Q05 | Patient-Centered Communication

SCENARIO When greeted with an offered handshake, a patient steps back and says, "I prefer not to shake hands for personal reasons." The patient remains engaged in the conversation and is ready to check in.

Which response best respects the patient's preference?

A. "Would you tell me which belief prevents you from shaking hands?"

B. "Thank you for letting me know. A verbal greeting is fine; how may I help?"

C. "Should I tell the provider that physical contact is not acceptable today?"

D. "Would you prefer that I greet your companion instead during this visit?"

Q06 | Telephone Written and Virtual Communication

> **SCENARIO** A verified patient writes in the clinic portal, "Please have the provider change my work note from three days off to two weeks." The medical assistant can route requests but is not authorized to change the provider's work restrictions. No revised note has been approved.

Which portal reply is most appropriate?

A. "I will send your request to the provider for review. The clinic will contact you with the response."
B. "I will prepare a two-week note today so you can give it to your employer."
C. "Please tell your employer that the provider will extend the note after reviewing it."
D. "Please bring a draft of the new note, and I will issue it with the provider's name."

Q07 | Accessible and Inclusive Communication

> **SCENARIO** An adult patient says, "I go by Alex and use they/them pronouns. Since my brain injury, I need extra time to answer." During intake, a companion repeatedly answers before Alex has time to speak. Alex says they want to answer the questions themselves.

Which approach best supports Alex's participation?

A. Ask the companion to give Alex's answers, then ask Alex to confirm them.
B. Give Alex all the questions together so they can prepare several answers.
C. Address Alex, ask one short question at a time, and allow time for a response.
D. Repeat each question more loudly if Alex does not answer immediately.

Q08 | Teamwork Conflict and Professionalism

> **SCENARIO** A medical assistant notices that a coworker has twice left the callback-number field blank on patient message forms. The omissions have required extra calls to obtain the numbers. No urgent message is currently waiting.

Which statement provides the most constructive initial feedback?

A. "Could we talk privately? Two messages lacked callback numbers, which delayed follow-up. Can we review the message checklist?"
B. "Could you explain the missing numbers at the staff meeting so everyone can learn from them?"
C. "Could you ask me to check each of your messages before sending it from now on?"
D. "Could you be more careful with paperwork? The team needs everyone to improve."

Q09 | Patient-Centered Communication

SCENARIO After speaking with the provider about an unexpected diagnosis, a patient becomes tearful while waiting for checkout instructions. The patient says, "I just need a moment." There is no immediate safety concern.

Which response best combines supportive words and nonverbal behavior?

A. Stand at the doorway and say, "Try to focus on the positive while I finish checkout."
B. Continue typing and say, "I am listening; let me know when you are ready to leave."
C. Hold the patient's hand without asking and say, "I know exactly how you feel."
D. Pause the task, sit at a comfortable distance, and say, "Take your time; I am here."

Q10 | Telephone Written and Virtual Communication

SCENARIO During virtual-visit setup, a patient can see the medical assistant, but the audio repeatedly cuts out. The assistant misses several words when the patient describes the reason for the visit. Clinic policy permits approved connection troubleshooting and requires notifying the clinician if effective communication cannot be restored.

Which action best addresses the communication problem?

A. Continue intake and infer the missing words from the patient's visible expression.
B. Record that the patient gave no additional concerns and complete the connection.
C. Explain the audio problem, try the approved troubleshooting steps, and notify the clinician if it persists.
D. End the video encounter and record it as completed because the patient successfully connected.

Q11 | Teamwork Conflict and Professionalism

SCENARIO A patient tells the medical assistant, "I have reported twice that staff call me by the wrong name, and it keeps happening." The patient is calm but asks to speak with someone who can address the repeated problem. Clinic policy allows documenting the preferred name in the designated field and referring unresolved service complaints to the office manager.

Which response best addresses this complaint?

A. "I am sorry this has continued. I will confirm the name you want us to use and ask the office manager to speak with you."
B. "I will remind today's staff of your name; please let us know if it happens at another visit."
C. "I understand your concern, but registration staff have many patients and may need more time."
D. "I will change your name in my notes, and you can explain the problem again at checkout."

Q12 | Teamwork Conflict and Professionalism

> **SCENARIO** At the front desk, a visitor says, "If you do not let me into the treatment area, I will hit you," and starts moving toward the staff-only doorway. Clinic policy directs staff to move to safety, warn nearby staff, and activate the designated emergency/security response for an immediate threat.

Which action best follows the stated policy?

A. Stand in the doorway and explain that the visitor must calm down before entering.

B. Move to safety, alert nearby staff, and activate the emergency/security response.

C. Invite the visitor into an empty examination room for a private conversation.

D. Continue discussing the complaint while waiting to see whether the visitor enters.

ANSWER KEY & EXPLANATIONS

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01 C	02 A	03 D	04 B	05 B	06 A
07 C	08 A	09 D	10 C	11 A	12 B

DETAILED EXPLANATIONS

Q01 | Correct answer: C

"What concerns would you like me to share with the provider today?"

An open-ended question invites the patient to identify their concerns before the team helps organize the visit. The assistant can record the concerns and relay them to the provider without deciding independently which concern deserves evaluation. Finishing a form before inviting the concerns can repeat the patient's experience of not being heard.

Q02 | Correct answer: A

Connect the qualified interpreter and address the patient directly.

A qualified interpreter supports accurate two-way communication, while the assistant continues speaking directly to the patient. Using a child as the primary interpreter can introduce errors and burden the child with sensitive information. Slower English or an unverified application does not meet this patient's stated communication need.

Q03 | Correct answer: D

"The patient reports lightheadedness this morning after starting a prescription yesterday and asks about the next dose. I have verified details for live transfer."

The handoff preserves the symptom, timing, patient question, and verified contact information while following the stated live-transfer policy. It avoids turning a reported sequence of events into a diagnosis or medication instruction. The absence of fainting does not justify minimizing or delaying the call.

Q04 | Correct answer: B

Move to a quieter area and face the patient while speaking clearly.

The patient has identified effective adjustments for this brief conversation: less background noise and a clear view of the speaker. Speaking clearly while facing the patient supports those preferences. Raising the volume alone or substituting another method without considering the patient's preference may not improve understanding.

Q05 | Correct answer: B

"Thank you for letting me know. A verbal greeting is fine; how may I help?"

Acknowledging the preference and continuing with a verbal greeting allows the encounter to proceed respectfully. The patient does not need to justify a personal greeting preference. Declining a handshake does not establish that the patient refuses a clinical examination or wants communication redirected to a companion.

Q06 | Correct answer: A

"I will send your request to the provider for review. The clinic will contact you with the response."

The reply clearly explains the next step without promising a decision that has not been made. Routing the request respects the assistant's stated role. Issuing a revised note or predicting approval would misrepresent the provider's decision.

Q07 | Correct answer: C

Address Alex, ask one short question at a time, and allow time for a response.

A direct conversation with one question at a time and adequate response time supports the need Alex described. A slower response does not establish that the companion should speak for Alex. Respectful communication also uses the name and pronouns the patient provided.

Q08 | Correct answer: A

"Could we talk privately? Two messages lacked callback numbers, which delayed follow-up. Can we review the message checklist?"

Private feedback that identifies specific observations, their effect, and a practical improvement supports teamwork. The message checklist gives both coworkers a concrete reference. A public discussion focused on one coworker or a vague request to be more careful is less useful for correcting this specific problem.

Q09 | Correct answer: D

Pause the task, sit at a comfortable distance, and say, "Take your time; I am here."

Pausing, allowing silence, and offering calm presence acknowledge the patient's expressed need. Sitting at a comfortable distance avoids assuming that touch would be welcome. Reassurance that redirects the patient toward positive thinking or continued typing can communicate that the patient should hurry past their distress.

Q10 | Correct answer: C

Explain the audio problem, try the approved troubleshooting steps, and notify the clinician if it persists.

The assistant should acknowledge an unreliable connection instead of treating partially heard information as complete. Approved troubleshooting may restore communication; persistent difficulty must be reported so the clinician can determine an appropriate next step. Connecting to a platform alone does not establish that a usable clinical exchange occurred.

Q11 | Correct answer: A

"I am sorry this has continued. I will confirm the name you want us to use and ask the office manager to speak with you."

The response acknowledges the repeated problem, confirms the patient's preference, and offers the policy-defined escalation the patient requested. The assistant should record the confirmed preference in the designated field and relay the complaint objectively. Another informal reminder alone does not address a complaint that remains unresolved after repeated reports.

Q12 | Correct answer: B

Move to safety, alert nearby staff, and activate the emergency/security response.

An explicit threat paired with movement toward a restricted area calls for the stated safety response. The assistant should create distance and summon help rather than try to resolve the complaint alone. Blocking the doorway or moving into a secluded room can increase exposure to the threatening visitor.

End of Practice Exam